

Hackathon Guidelines

18th – 22nd August 2025

Hackathon Theme: **“Innovating for an Inclusive and Resilient Future”**

At its core, this theme is a clarion call for rigorous intellectual inquiry and bold creative expression, a challenge to move beyond incremental improvements toward systemic transformation. “Innovation” here transcends technology; it is an invitation to rethink structures, narratives, and experiences. “Inclusivity” foregrounds the moral imperative of leaving no one behind, while “resilience” underscores the need to design for enduring impact amidst volatility and uncertainty.

This theme resonates deeply with the G20 2025 priorities and aligns seamlessly with the intellectual and practical foundations of our qualifications.

Focus Areas:

These focus areas are derived directly from the G20’s broad priority areas. This is to provide a globally relevant, future-facing scaffold for your intellectual and creative explorations.

- Digital transformation for business, government, and society
- AI, data-driven, and creative solutions for social impact
- Cybersecurity, trust, and digital ethics
- Climate action, sustainability, and responsible design
- Financial and social inclusion
- Future of work and digital upskilling
- Public sector innovation and local governance
- Inclusive brand storytelling and creative activism

AAA Students

Alignment with your studies.

Leverage your expertise in:

- Marketing & Marketing Communication
- Digital Marketing & Social Media Strategy
- Consumer Behaviour & Brand Management
- Creative Brand Communication
- Art Direction, Graphic Design & Copywriting
- Visual Communication & Design Thinking
- Campaign Planning & Activations
- Research, Media Planning & Buying

Core topic clusters and sample Hackathon challenges

1. Digital Transformation for Inclusive Growth

In an era where digital innovation reshapes every sector, marketers and brand strategists play a critical role in designing solutions that foster equitable access and societal upliftment. AAA students can conceptualize campaigns and digital experiences that transform how communities engage with education, health, and essential services shaping perceptions and driving behavioral change.

2. AI, Emerging Tech & Creative Public Good

As technology evolves, the need for ethically grounded, human-centered applications grows. AAA students, skilled in storytelling and consumer insight, can lead creative interpretations of AI and emerging technologies framing complex tech narratives into accessible, inspiring public good campaigns that inform and empower.

3. Cybersecurity and Digital Trust

Trust is the cornerstone of brand equity and consumer loyalty. AAA students can explore how to communicate the critical importance of digital safety, privacy, and ethical data use, creating campaigns that humanize cybersecurity and build societal confidence in digital platforms and brands.

4. Financial and Social Inclusion

Marketing is a powerful catalyst for social equity and empowerment. Students can craft narratives and educational campaigns that demystify financial systems, highlight accessible financial services, and promote inclusive economic participation especially for marginalized communities and informal sector actors.

5. Climate and Sustainable Innovation

Sustainability is no longer optional; it is integral to future-fit brand identities. AAA students can conceptualize campaigns that advocate for environmental responsibility, amplify climate action, and position brands as authentic champions of sustainability, thus influencing societal behavior and policy conversations.

6. Employment and Future of Work

As the nature of work transforms, so too must the narratives around it. Students can develop communication strategies and multimedia campaigns that support digital upskilling, highlight entrepreneurial journeys, and celebrate new forms of meaningful work aligning closely with both brand purpose and societal progress.

7. Inclusive Brand Storytelling & Creative Activism

Brands today are cultural actors, not just economic entities. AAA students can leverage their deep skills in visual and narrative communication to craft campaigns that advocate for diversity, equity, inclusion, and social justice making brands agents of positive cultural transformation.

8. Empowering SMMEs

Small businesses are vital to economic resilience and community well-being. AAA students can create campaigns and brand strategies that elevate SMMEs, tell their stories authentically, and empower them to connect with wider audiences supporting inclusive growth and local innovation.

Richfield Students:

Alignment with your studies.

Apply your skills and knowledge from:

- Artificial Intelligence & Machine Learning
- Cyber Security & Forensics
- Data Science & Big Data Analytics
- Cloud Computing & Emerging Technologies
- Software Engineering & Mobile App Development
- Programming & Web Technologies
- Business Analysis & Strategic Management
- Entrepreneurship & Innovation
- Finance, Economics & Supply Chain Management
- Public Policy, Governance & Local Government Management

Core topic clusters and sample Hackathon challenges

1. Digital Transformation for Inclusive Growth

- Design an app that improves access to education or healthcare in under-resourced communities.
- Create data-driven solutions to support small businesses with supply chain resilience.
- Build an AI-powered chatbot for farmers to enhance market access and climate adaptation.

2. AI, Emerging Tech & Creative Public Good

- Develop an AI system that detects and combats misinformation affecting public health or elections.
- Prototype a predictive analytics or creative visual dashboard for disaster response.

- Create an IoT or robotics-based solution for environmental monitoring and awareness campaigns.

3. Cybersecurity and Digital Trust

- Design an engaging cybersecurity awareness campaign or app for youth and entrepreneurs.
- Create a blockchain or transparent tracking system for ethical supply chains.
- Propose a creative storytelling campaign addressing online safety and digital identity.

4. Financial and Social Inclusion

- Develop a fintech app promoting financial literacy and inclusion for informal workers.
- Create a data visualization tool for tracking progress toward SDGs at municipal level.
- Design a campaign that demystifies access to micro-insurance or digital financial services.

5. Climate and Sustainable Innovation

- Build a climate finance tracker app linking green projects with investors.
- Design a creative campaign encouraging plastic reduction and responsible consumption.
- Create a carbon footprint calculator for SMEs, paired with brand activation ideas.

6. Employment and Future of Work

- Develop a job matching or digital upskilling platform for underserved communities.

- Create a virtual mentorship or training platform using immersive storytelling.
- Design a creative communication campaign promoting entrepreneurship and gig economy opportunities.

7. Empowering SMMEs

Small, Medium, and Micro Enterprises (SMMEs) are vital catalysts for economic dynamism and social resilience. In South Africa and globally, SMMEs drive job creation, foster local innovation, and strengthen community networks, yet they remain vulnerable to market volatility, digital divides, and systemic inequities.

Possible challenges under this focus:

- Design digital tools that help SMMEs digitise operations and improve market access.
- Develop fintech or microfinance platforms to enhance financial inclusion for small businesses.
- Create data visualization dashboards highlighting the contributions of SMMEs to local economies.
- Conceptualize brand storytelling campaigns celebrating SMME impact and fostering consumer trust.
- Build training ecosystems or virtual mentorship platforms to equip SMME owners with future-focused skills.

Team composition and inter-campus competition

Each campus will facilitate the formation of teams, with a maximum of five members per group. Importantly, in campuses where AAA and Richfield students are co-located, teams will be mixed intentionally, allowing AAA students to join Richfield students in a single, unified group. This strategic integration recognises that innovation is inherently interdisciplinary, the Hackathon is not just for IT students, but equally for those in Business and Creative disciplines.

We encourage teams to approach their projects as holistic ventures: a Richfield student might focus on technical development and coding; a Marketing student could

craft the brand strategy and communication aesthetics; and a Creative student might conceptualize compelling visuals, storytelling elements, or user experience design. In this way, each team will mirror the complexity of real-world innovation, where diverse expertise converges to create impactful solutions.

Competition timeline and selection process

This year's Hackathon will follow a different structure compared to previous editions. The first round of campus competitions will take place from 18 to 22 August 2025, where all teams from both Richfield and AAA will present their solutions. Following this round, five top-performing groups per campus will be selected to proceed to the prestigious Institutional Hackathon Competition in October 2025. During this final stage, the most outstanding teams from all campuses (including Distance Learning) will compete at an institutional level, with winners announced in the same week.

This year's Hackathon will not only challenge your skills but also open pathways to remarkable opportunities and recognition, including exclusive, high-profile prizes for the top teams. In addition, the most outstanding ideas may be further refined and positioned for potential submission to the G20 official academic and policy outreach streams, giving our students a rare opportunity to contribute to global conversations on inclusive growth, sustainability, and innovation. While we look forward to sharing more details on these exciting rewards in due course, we encourage you to focus now on assembling diverse, dynamic teams and developing transformative, future-oriented ideas.